

Introduction

A government may be compartmentalized to negative or positive connotations depending on the ideologies and beliefs taken by the corresponding population following discussions or approaches governments publicize on certain topics, especially political ones. These discussions and actions involve the perspectives of economics, morals, actions taken for the future, actions done in response to historical conflicts, etc. Characteristics assigned to governments and their influence may be classified as ‘corrupt’ if ongoing negative standpoints and evaluations by the public are perceived. Corruption is a term that may additionally be assigned to a government depending on approach—es taken or changed in regards to how everyday laws, life and rights are shaped. According to a publication written by John Clammer, a professor with certifications of a D.Phil in social anthropology, “A ‘functional’ system is one that allows a reasonably secure normal human social life to flourish and also extends the range of that life beyond the satisfaction of basic needs into areas of cultural creativity, psychic security and leisure—a point validly promoted by the now largely abandoned ‘basic human needs’ theory of development priorities developed in the 1980s” (114). Systems of government declared as functional and operational within equitable governance often require providing fundamental human rights to safety and to other regards as declared by international courts, as well as the authorization of citizen-contributed growth from within; without these significant deliverables towards their nation, governments may be identified as abusing their power, therefore gaining the label of corruptness.

Claim #1: The Philosophical Lens on Government Corruption Through The Protection and Provision of Human Rights Perspective.

Initially, for a government to acquire an honorable reputation through ethical definitions, basic rights in relation to the internationally recognized and fundamental document of human rights must be in order within the country for the citizens. According to the internationally recognized Universal Declaration of Human Rights by the United Nations, an organization that specializes in international affairs, these rights are defined in hopes they are applied globally, “Whereas recognition of the inherent dignity and of the equal and inalienable rights of all members of the human family is the foundation of freedom, justice and peace in the world...” (1). Grounds for every citizen to be provided with the opportunity to indulge in basic human rights allows a government to be recognized as one that attempts to raise their nation in an ethical manner. However, the opposite is also stated in regards to governments earning an unfavorable status globally from the continued recognized document of Universal Declaration of Rights, “Whereas disregard and contempt for human rights have resulted in barbarous acts which have outraged the conscience of mankind, and the advent of a world in which human beings shall enjoy freedom of speech and belief and freedom from fear and want has been proclaimed as the highest aspiration of the common people...” (1). If these foundations are unbuilt or unrecognized by officials of a nation, government influences may be referred to as officially ‘corrupt’. This status is associated with the ethical terminology of what a nation may be classified as, based on whether basic and fundamental human rights are being provided or taken from the corresponding population. In other terms, violating the defined human rights disengages a population from recognized safety to hardship, therefore blame becoming assigned to the nations’ government with a recognition in corruption

Furthermore, article 2 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights states, “Everyone is entitled to all the rights and freedoms set forth in this Declaration, without distinction of any kind...Furthermore, no distinction shall be made on the basis of the political, jurisdictional or international status of the country or territory to which a person belongs, whether it be independent, trust, non-self-governing or under any other limitation of sovereignty” (2). Article 2 furthermore emphasizes the importance of each government affiliated with a nation, and their implementation of basic human rights within. The article highlights the importance of this definition applying to ‘everyone’, not to certain individuals nor families who may possess extended connections and networks to individuals in government. Additionally, this article supports the argument that ethically, basic human rights that are not provided to everyone because of class, race, gender, and other factors may qualify that government in being labelled as corrupt or dysfunctional, “...Without distinction of any kind, such as race, colour, sex, language, religion, political or other opinion, national or social origin, property, birth or other status.” (Article 2). Basic human rights being provided by each nation's government is a strict necessity that, according to the United Nations, should not be abused nor go unimplemented in civil nations.

The Philosophical Lens on Government Corruption Through The Authorization of Citizen-Contributed Growth Towards a Nation Perspective.

Another significant point can be attributed to what citizens from a nation can accomplish through their authority for the betterment of the society as a whole. Governments that allow citizens to have a voice or stand in nationwide affairs, such as elections, often see significant improvement with nationwide satisfaction and new helpful policy implementations. These improvements can include an improvement on the ranking of rated corrupt countries, as

evidenced through the World Bank Group, a group that provides financial and technical assistance to developing countries through its five primary organizations. The World Bank Group utilizes Uruguay as an example of a nation that demonstrates improvement through the implementation of policy platforms, defined as the policies that certain political groups or individuals support. “For most of the 19th and 20th centuries in Uruguay, the overall quality of public services was low, and political connections were the main vehicle for accessing the goods and services provided by the state... Today, Uruguay is ranked the world’s 21st least-corrupt country, according to Transparency International’s 2015 Corruption Perceptions Index (Transparency International 2015). ...the creation of programmatic parties after civilian rule was reestablished in 1985 played an important role. Social groups made efforts to build coalitions with interest groups that shared the same preferences...” (17). The opening statements demonstrate the rise of success that Uruguay has achieved, while the rest of the paragraph, through the report, explains the contributing factors towards this accelerated rise. Uruguay governments are described as ones that have shifted from a political system that was focused on clientelism— a system that favors higher-class citizens or those closer to the government— to a system that relied on citizen input and the policy platforms. A strong correlation between these factors can be noticed, as citizen input can increase citizen participation within the government, leading to lessened corrupt and hidden systems, as explained by the World Bank Group: “The experience of Uruguay illustrates how multiple mechanisms of engagement can help citizens influence the policy arena by changing incentives, preferences, and contestability to generate more equitable development. Modes of citizen engagement include elections, political organizations, social organizations, and direct participation and deliberation” (17). Uruguay is a

country that exhibits true and positive change through strongly correlated ideas such as giving citizens the right to authorized and contributed growth towards their nation.

Conclusion

Ultimately, the significance of the reputation of a government carries to international and national levels in regards to the wellbeing of the nation's citizens, and its future. Identifying whether a government may possess corrupt qualities is a subjective topic, hence having determining factors makes identification simpler; or, adds on to the controversy. Those factors can include ideas such as views on basic rights, and if the opportunity to contribute growth to a nation from within is available. An opportunity to create a solid definition for governmental corruption is attempted by Transparency International, a global, civil society nonprofit. This source attempts to define governmental corruption, "The abuse of high-level power that benefits the few at the expense of the many...often goes unpunished" (1). Despite the evidence of multiple definitions for corruption available, there is no set definition that also contributes towards global impacts, such as the definition provided by Transparency International, or even the United Nations. Philosophical viewpoints on the definition of when a government may be called corrupt is a fundamental step in a direction towards understanding a free society, one free from corruption.

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